CSIS AUSTRALIA CHAIR

# Australia Daily Brief

Sunday, November 1, 2026

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**RE:** Fiji constitution vote could fall short of two-thirds · NZ coalition splits over vote-splitting ad · Chalmers, Gallagher dodge budget savings pledge · Albanese departs for CHOGM, UN bid · RBA rate rise expected Tuesday

| ASX 200 | AUD/USD | NZX 50 | NZD/USD |
|---|---|---|---|
| 8,908 | 0.7035 | 13,797 | 0.5633 |
| +1.28% | +0.07% | +0.36% | -1.21% |

IN THIS ISSUE Top Stories · Overnight · Stat · Pacific · New Zealand · Canberra · Markets · Documents · Upcoming · The Wire

## TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. Fiji's parliament moves toward a Monday vote on the Constitution (Amendment) Bill with the National Federation Party and SODELPA withdrawing support, a shift that could drop the government's count from 38 votes to 31.
2. Luxon disavows a vote-splitting advertisement signed off by coalition partners ACT and NZ First, exposing strain six days before New Zealand's November 7 election.
3. Gallagher and Chalmers both decline to guarantee net budget savings in December's mid-year update after a 4.3 percent inflation print raised expectations of a Reserve Bank rate rise on Tuesday.

## TOP STORIES

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

### Albanese departs for CHOGM as UN Security Council bid advances

**Anthony Albanese** travels to Antigua and Barbuda for the 28th Commonwealth Heads of Government Meeting at the personal request of **King Charles**. The prime minister will press Australia's campaign for a UN Security Council seat for 2029-30 and discuss climate, oceans, trade and AI regulation with leaders from *56 nations*. Coalition critics accused him of "jetting off" as households await Tuesday's expected interest rate rise.

per ABC News: "Albanese flies to Caribbean for summit as households brace for rate pain"

PACIFIC-POLITICS

### Fiji's constitutional overhaul teeters as coalition partners withdraw support

Fiji's Constitution (Amendment) Bill faces a third-reading vote after the National Federation Party and SODELPA said they would not support it as drafted. Town hall moderator **Stanley Simpson** said support could fall from *38 votes recorded on October 2 to 31*, short of the two-thirds threshold. Deputy Prime Minister **Manoa Kamikamica** said the bill reflects 75 percent of the Constitution Review Commission's recommendations and called the immunity end date "a typo" to be corrected to October 6, 2014.

per Fiji Sun: "Constitution vote hangs in balance"

AU-POLITICS

### Gallagher refuses savings pledge before December budget update

Finance Minister **Katy Gallagher** told ABC Insiders the government cannot promise net savings in December's mid-year budget update given mounting fiscal pressure. Treasurer **Jim Chalmers** declined the same commitment this week after a *4.3 percent* annual inflation print raised expectations of a Reserve Bank rate rise on Tuesday. Gallagher said all spending remains under review as decisions are finalized.

per ABC News: "Government will not promise net savings in budget update, despite inflation pressure" · also SMH: "Gallagher won't guarantee Labor will cut more than it spends despite mounting pressure"

NZ-POLITICS

### Luxon disowns coalition partners' vote-splitting ad six days from election

**Christopher Luxon** said he was disappointed that coalition partners ACT and NZ First signed off on an advertisement urging voters to split their ballots away from National, days before New Zealand's November 7 election. The three parties are competing for the same right-of-centre vote, with NZ First leader **Winston Peters** telling a Papakura crowd not to give their party vote to National.

per 1News: "National, ACT and NZ First at odds over vote-splitting campaign"

## OVERNIGHT

AU-POLITICS

Newspoll: Labor hits equal-lowest primary vote, Chalmers rated worst minister · The Australian

Newspoll recorded Labor's equal-lowest primary vote of the term, with **Jim Chalmers** ranked the worst-performing minister among those surveyed. The result lands two days before the Reserve Bank's Tuesday meeting, where economists expect a further rate rise, and as the government declines to commit to net budget savings in December.

AU-DEFENSE

Ex-intelligence official says big tech's copyright 'security' case is a bluff · SMH

A former senior intelligence official told the Sydney Morning Herald that major technology companies are exploiting national security arguments to push the Albanese government to weaken copyright protections. He warned the proposed changes could leave Australia more exposed to cyberattacks.

AU-DEFENSE

ABC traces rising operational-technology hacking risk to infrastructure · ABC News

An ABC investigation links Australia's exposure to operational-technology hacking to the 2000 Maroochy Shire incident, when more than *800,000 litres* of untreated sewage spilled into Sunshine Coast waterways after an attack on wastewater pumps. It cites hackers raising fridge temperatures across French supermarkets last month and attacks on 30 US water systems in July.

AU-DEFENSE

Victoria Barracks Sydney among 67 Defence sites flagged for sale · ABC Politics

A retired colonel called the planned sale of Victoria Barracks in Sydney's Paddington "mind-boggling," after an independent audit found the Defence estate too costly to maintain. The 1840s barracks on 13 hectares is one of *67 underused or vacant Defence properties* earmarked for disposal.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

CCP purge leaves five of seven military commission seats empty · ABC Politics

Only two of seven members remain on China's Central Military Commission, including **Xi Jinping**, after the fifth plenum expelled 33 Central Committee members and alternates, 16 of them from the military. The anti-corruption campaign has punished *7.9 million* party members and officials over 14 years.

AU-POLITICS

Polling suggests One Nation's Victorian surge may be losing steam · Guardian Australia

Internal Greens polling shared with Guardian Australia shows the party's statewide primary vote now ahead of **Pauline Hanson**'s One Nation in Victoria. Opposition leader **Jess Wilson** made her first public criticism of Hanson's party this week as the state election approaches.

## STAT OF THE DAY

# 4.3%

Australia's annual inflation rate to the September quarter

The hotter-than-expected print drove expectations of a Reserve Bank rate rise on Tuesday and underlies the government's refusal to promise net budget savings in December.

ABC News

## PACIFIC WIRE

FIJI · FIJI SUN

**Australia to station justice official in Fiji under renewed partnership**

Australian High Commissioner **Peter Roberts** announced Canberra will station a full-time Attorney-General's Department representative in Fiji from next year under a renewed law and justice partnership. The programme will support legislative drafting and Fiji's law and justice sector reform roadmap, Roberts told the Fiji Law Society Convention in Nadi.

COOK ISLANDS · COOK ISLANDS NEWS

**Cook Islands to upgrade four airports under $1.2 billion climate fund**

Cook Islands will upgrade at least four Southern Group airports through a newly approved *US$1.2 billion* Pacific climate programme, co-chaired by the nation and funded by the Green Climate Fund, one of the largest regional climate financing commitments reported this year.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

**PNG graduates 25 fisheries observers to strengthen maritime surveillance**

Papua New Guinea graduated 25 newly trained fisheries observers in Kavieng, New Ireland Province, expanding its capacity to monitor fishing activity and protect tuna stocks amid continued regional concern over illegal fishing.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

**South Fly communities face severe water shortage amid prolonged El Nino**

Communities in the Forecoast area of Kiwai LLG, Western Province, face a serious drinking water shortage as prolonged El Nino dry conditions continue to affect rural Papua New Guinea villages, compounding pressure on already stretched services.

FIJI · FIJI SUN

**Fiji covers two-thirds of tractor cost for Macuata farming cooperative**

Agriculture Minister **Tomasi Tunabuna** handed a tractor to a 15-member farming cooperative in Macuata under a scheme in which government covers two-thirds of machinery costs, aimed at improving productivity as farmers face a prolonged dry spell.

FIJI · FIJI SUN

**Fiji minister warns El Nino drought could extend into mid-2027**

Minister **Tomasi Tunabuna** said El Nino's effects on Fiji could persist until March 2027 or longer, threatening sugarcane production and water supplies as farmers race to finish harvesting before the Labasa Sugar Mill's crushing season closes.

## NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · NZ HERALD

**Peters says foreign country interested in building Kaikohe airport**

NZ First leader **Winston Peters** said a foreign country has expressed interest in building an airport at Kaikohe, during campaigning in Northland. He did not name the country in comments reported six days before New Zealand's November 7 election.

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ PACIFIC

**Peters dismisses 78-year-old cost-of-living critic as having 'memory problems'**

**Winston Peters** told a Papakura rally that a 78-year-old woman who questioned NZ First's record on the cost of living must have "memory problems." He cited pension increases and the abolition of the superannuation surtax, after the woman's social media post pointed to higher food and power bills.

NZ-POLITICS · FINANCIAL TIMES

**The ex-KPMG consultant who could be New Zealand's kingmaker**

The Financial Times profiles a former KPMG consultant positioned as a potential kingmaker ahead of New Zealand's November 7 election, underscoring how tight the three-way contest between National, ACT and NZ First has become in the campaign's final week.

## CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · ABC POLITICS

**Liberal MP pushes party to rule out superannuation changes**

Liberal MP **Garth Hamilton** told ABC's Insiders he is pushing his party to rule out any changes to superannuation, amid pressure on the Coalition over retirement savings policy, as the government separately faces calls to find budget savings before December's update.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

### Federal inquiry weighs paid reproductive leave for Australian workers

A federal inquiry into Australia's National Employment Standards is examining calls from unions, lawyers and advocates for at least *10 days* of non-cumulative paid reproductive leave on top of existing sick leave. The inquiry is expected to report later in 2026.

AU-POLITICS · GUARDIAN AUSTRALIA

### Taylor presses Albanese on 'out-of-control' spending in Question Time

Opposition Leader **Angus Taylor** opened Question Time asking whether **Anthony Albanese** would "admit Labor's out-of-control spending is forcing families and small businesses to pay more for everything." The Guardian reports defence, the NDIS and health drive much of the increased outlays, leaving Treasurer Jim Chalmers few levers before December's update.

## BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · AFR

### AustralianSuper's new CIO confronts $70 billion private asset problem

AustralianSuper's new chief investment officer **Shaun Manuell** must address a *$70 billion* private asset exposure that threatens to erode gains after he won the top investment job at the fund, the AFR reports.

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

### Rinehart criticises government spending as Hancock Prospecting profit falls

**Gina Rinehart** criticised federal government spending and the net-zero agenda after Hancock Prospecting reported a drop in mining profit, adding business-sector pressure to the government's budget position.

TRADE-ECONOMY · PNG POST-COURIER

### Kumul Petroleum says Papua LNG financing relies on domestic borrowing

Kumul Petroleum Holdings clarified that the funding structure for the Papua LNG project relies entirely on domestic borrowing and internal cash flows rather than direct public funds, addressing concerns raised about the sector's financing.

TRADE-ECONOMY · FIJI SUN

### Fijian Holdings tops $1 billion in assets, shifts focus to profitability

Fijian Holdings Limited reported total assets of *$1.09 billion* for the financial year, with chairman **Rokoseru Nabalarua** saying the milestone must translate into stronger earnings. Profit before tax rose 11 percent to $67 million despite rising fuel and operating costs.

## PRIMARY DOCUMENTS

JOINT STATEMENT · AU MINISTERIAL

### Quad Joint Press Release on Economic Prosperity and Security

Australia's Minister for Foreign Affairs **Penny Wong** published a Quad joint press release on economic prosperity and security, part of ongoing coordination among Australia, the United States, Japan and India on regional economic resilience.

## UPCOMING

**NOV 2**

### Fiji parliament's scheduled third-reading vote on the Constitution (Amendment) Bill

Determines whether the government can reach the two-thirds majority needed after NFP and SODELPA withdrew support.

**NOV 3**

### Reserve Bank of Australia board meets, Tuesday rate decision

A rate rise is widely expected after a 4.3 percent inflation print, adding to pressure on December's budget update.

**NOV 7**

### New Zealand general election

Decides whether the National-ACT-NZ First coalition continues amid public rifts over vote-splitting strategy.

**DEC 2026**

### Australian Mid-Year Economic and Fiscal Outlook (MYEFO)

Will show whether Chalmers delivers net savings after declining to guarantee them amid rising inflation.

## THE WIRE

PACIFIC-POLITICS · FIJI SUN

### Rabi leaders press for Banaban Senate seat left out of Constitution Bill

Rabi Council of Leaders administrator **Iakoba Karutake** said he was "disappointed" that a Senate seat for a Banaban representative was dropped from Fiji's Constitution (Amendment) Bill. Deputy Prime Minister Manoa Kamikamica said he would ask the committee to reconsider.

PACIFIC-POLITICS · COOK ISLANDS NEWS

### Cook Islands hospitality sector presses for fast-track working holiday visa

The Cook Islands Restaurant and Hospitality Association says it is still awaiting a government response to its proposal for a fast-tracked working holiday visa aimed at easing persistent workforce shortages in tourism.


# CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

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